

How the budget fight could hit the EU's global reach

送信者: POLITICO Brussels Playbook 受信日時: 2026-09-22 13:51

【メール原文】

Presented by Google By NICHOLAS VINOCUR with MAX GRIERA GREETINGS. It's Nick Vinocur. Let's dive in. In today's Playbook: — A key Giorgia Meloni ally

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By NICHOLAS VINOCUR

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GREETINGS. It's Nick Vinocur. Let's dive in.

In today's Playbook:

- A key Giorgia Meloni ally says Brussels will need to learn to work with Marine Le Pen.
- EU ministers have a last chance to request changes to the bloc's long-term budget.
- Faces in the crowd: Hanna Saarinen, Alisher Usmanov, Věra Jourová, Leo Brincat, Mikhail Fridman, Erkki Liikanen, Alexander Stubb, Dagmar Roth-Behrendt, Thomas Byrne and more ...

On today's Brussels Playbook Podcast: Zoya and Ian discuss whether Donald Trump really is done talking about taking Greenland.

A message from Google: Google has opened Connected Cup, an AI pop-up in the Brussels EU Quarter. How is AI made and used in Europe today? Come and find out. Open to everyone, weekdays 08:00 to 16:00 until 16 October, with a coffee area, product demos and events. Explore the programme .

DRIVING THE DAY

BUDGET SCARE: The European Commission has internally simulated the impact of slashing its development aid budget by as much as 40% in its next long-term budget — raising the specter of job cuts in EU delegations around the world, EU officials and diplomats told Playbook.

The worst case: The simulations, which are hypothetical and don't amount to operational plans, examined the potential impact of deep cuts to the €80 billion budget of the EU's Global Europe program over a seven-year period starting in 2028. Many staffers paid from this budget work in EU delegations around the world — so cuts would theoretically shrink the EU's global footprint.

The simulation — which comes amid growing pressure from frugal countries led by Germany to slash the next long-term budget — established that hundreds of jobs would need to be cut in units such as DG MENA, DG INTPA and DG ENEST, likely via non-replacement. “If you cut the development budget by 40%, then mechanically you need to reduce jobs by 40%,” said one EU official.

The move also coincides with efforts by Paris and Berlin to explore reforms of the foreign policy apparatus — whose delegations are partly funded via Global Europe funds.

Capitals are quietly discussing Global Europe as a potential place to cut given sensitivities around agriculture subsidies, cohesion funds and other areas defended by some countries, per two EU diplomats.

Trial balloon: During a gathering of EU ambassadors last week, a representative from DG BUDG floated various scenarios for what would happen to EU programs if the overall long-term budget is cut without any reduction to agricultural subsidies, cohesion funds or security.

Three diplomats said the move was interpreted as a “scare tactic” or “horror scenario,” intended to jolt deadlocked capitals, rather than as a serious proposal. “You don’t react to such a proposal,” said one EU diplomat. Another said that frugal countries wanted “horizontal” cuts across services.

What the Commission says: “As in all MFF negotiations, all scenarios and their consequences are discussed. Member states have consistently asked the Commission to inform their decisions with scenarios,” said a spokesperson.

The prospect of cuts is prompting jitters among non-governmental groups. “The EU cannot claim global leadership while considering cuts of nearly half its budget for international cooperation,” said Hanna Saarinen, senior EU aid policy adviser at Oxfam.

The wider view: The cuts would come as EU countries are trying to make the bloc’s diplomacy more effective and maximize its influence in multilateral forums. At an informal Foreign Affairs Council in Ireland earlier this month, for example, ministers discussed how to improve EU countries’ chances of securing top-level international jobs — such as the U.N. secretary-general’s post, which opens up at the end of the year.

BIG AND BREAKING

SANCTIONS STALLED: Ambassadors will resume talks on the EU’s Russia sanctions at 8 a.m. after failing to reach an agreement late last night. A compromise is likely to remove billionaires Alisher Usmanov and Mikhail Fridman from the list in exchange for extending sanctions on hundreds of others.

MERZ’S DILEMMA: Chancellor Friedrich Merz insists his unpopular reforms are necessary to revive Germany’s economy — but he’s running out of time to convince voters.

DON’T PANIC: Finnish President Alexander Stubb says Europe should prepare for more hybrid Russian attacks but mustn’t “overreact” to Moscow’s provocations, Hans von der Burchard reports from UNGA in New York .

OPENING THE ECF: About a dozen countries are circulating an unofficial document that calls for the defense section of the European Competitiveness Fund to be open to third countries, according to my colleagues on Morning Defense (for subscribers).

RIGHT TURN AHEAD

EXCLUSIVE — PLAY NICE WITH LE PEN: EU institutions and the center-right European People's Party must be ready to work with Marine Le Pen if she wins the French presidency — just as they did after Giorgia Meloni came to power in Italy, Nicola Procaccini, co-chair of the European Conservatives and Reformists group in the European Parliament, told Max Grier.

The more the merrier: For the right-wing ECR, a Le Pen victory would mean another like-minded ally among the leaders of Europe's biggest countries, helping it push a more euroskeptic agenda.

For example: The National Rally's proposal to halve its EU budget contribution doesn't bother Procaccini, Meloni's man in the Parliament. On the contrary, he welcomes it, saying his group "doesn't believe in a super-giant budget" anyway. (Read Max's full write-up of the interview [here](#).)

The "Meloni way" of dealing with the European Commission — "pragmatic, frank, open, honest and coherent" — would be the best path for Le Pen, Procaccini said. While "the French right historically is less pro-West than us, less pro-Europe also than us," he is "optimistic" that Le Pen wouldn't be destructive in Brussels.

For the EPP, which is increasingly voting alongside groups to its right in Parliament, a Le Pen victory would speed up a reckoning over how to deal with parties it had long kept at arm's length.

Procaccini said the EPP needs to have "courage" and more openly embrace majorities with right-wing and far-right parties. The EPP insists it doesn't negotiate with the far right but merely puts forward its position, which the far right may or may not agree with.

ECR lawmakers already sometimes negotiate with the far-right Patriots for Europe and then with the EPP, acting as informal mediators because the EPP doesn't want to deal directly with the Patriots. "But there's not a playbook," Procaccini said. "It happens sometimes, often, but it's not a scheme."

"I hope there's no need [for] this role, but if there's a need to be a sort of bridge, we are able to be the bridge" if the National Rally governs France, he said.

****Go beyond the headlines and discover who's behind Playbook and its podcast, with an insider's look at the people, rivalries and decisions shaping Europe's political agenda. Register now to watch online Brussels Playbook Live , happening today at 2 p.m.****

20-SECOND PLAYBOOK PRIMER

Brussels has unveiled an environmental rating scheme for data centers that power artificial intelligence — but how will that work? The rules will oblige big data centers to display a label grading them on their energy efficiency, water usage and clean power uptake on a scale of A to G, a bit like you get on the EU's appliances ranking. The labels will be generated automatically each year from figures companies are already required to report under the bloc's energy efficiency rules.

TALK TO PLAYBOOK: On the Brussels Playbook Podcast, Zoya asked whether the EU's proposed €2 tax on cheap parcels will make you think twice about online shopping. WhatsApp us on +32 491 050629

and listen from 7 a.m. to hear if we give you a shoutout.

BUDGET SHOWDOWN

WILL MINISTERS SHOW THEIR MFF CARDS? European affairs ministers this morning will have a last chance to suggest changes to the EU's next seven-year budget before a new negotiating document is unveiled in early October.

The Irish presidency of the Council of the EU, which is steering the budget talks and preparing the document, has urged ministers to put their cards on the table during the General Affairs Council. "Member states must now begin to identify where they may be able to compromise," Ireland wrote in the preparatory note seen by Playbook. But with the debate being livestreamed, ministers are unlikely to be candid.

Ireland asked Europe ministers to pick their three most important spending programs, signal whether they're open to increasing contributions to the EU budget and suggest changes that would make EU-wide taxes (or own resources) more palatable. "With any particular proposal that is nowhere near unanimity or can't be changed ... you have to question whether to put it forward," said Ireland's Europe Minister Thomas Byrne.

Montenegro progress update: The EU won't close chapters 18 and 19 of Montenegro's accession negotiations at today's GAC, Byrne said yesterday, with some member countries still working through procedural issues before that can happen. Byrne said the EU may instead hold an intergovernmental conference between now and next month's GAC to get those chapters signed off.

6 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

THE MEPS TO WATCH: POLITICO has compiled a list of 17 lawmakers who are making things happen in the European Parliament.

AVERTING AN AI DISASTER: Lawmakers are pushing to expand the EU's AI regulations to include "product liability" requirements to make American tech companies confront the risks posed by their most advanced models, Pieter Haeck and Sam Clark report.

Also: Several European countries were among 22 nations that adopted a declaration Monday saying AI "must remain under human direction, oversight and control" and calling for a global supervisory regime.

RUSSIAN RECRUITS: Western platforms are carrying ads that funnel young men into Russia's war machine , Antoaneta Roussi reports.

EXCLUSIVE — NEW ETHICS WATCHDOGS: These experts have been nominated to the new EU ethics body tasked with setting common standards among institutions, according to a document seen by POLITICO: Former Czech Commissioner Věra Jourová; Maltese politician Leo Brincat; former Finnish Commissioner Erkki Liikanen; former European Parliament Vice President Dagmar Roth-Behrendt; and former MEP Élisabeth Morin-Chartier. They need to be approved by the Commission, Parliament and Council.

DRUG WAR: U.S. trade officials are probing German drug prices today , following President Donald Trump claims that they're being subsidized by higher costs in America — and the consequences could

extend beyond pharmaceuticals.

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Partly sunny. High 20C.

BRUSSELS PLAYBOOK LIVE: Join us for our event today, which is packed with interesting speakers from Brussels and global politics:

1. Canada's Ambassador-designate to the EU Jonathan Wilkinson will give his first sit-down interview since arriving in the Belgian capital — and since Ursula von der Leyen's shock announcement last week that Canada could become an "associate member" of the EU.
2. Ukraine Deputy Prime Minister Vsevolod Chentsov will discuss the latest on the security situation, as top European officials grow increasingly alarmed that Russia could stage drone or missile attacks against NATO countries.
3. France's Minister Delegate for European Affairs Benjamin Haddad and Poland's Secretary of State in the Foreign Affairs Ministry Ignacy Niemczycki will add their perspective on the EU budget.

And there's loads more ... including MEPs, your Playbook team chatting about how this beautiful newsletter comes together each day (because it always does, somehow!), a special live recording of the Brussels Playbook Podcast ... and a very exciting Playbook announcement.

Watch Brussels Playbook Live here from 2 p.m., and register to watch here if you haven't already.

BUT THERE'S ONE NOTABLE ABSENCE: The U.S. ambassador to the EU, Andrew Puzder, yesterday canceled his onstage interview at today's event.

The decision was to ensure his appearance doesn't overlap with Donald Trump's speech at the U.N. General Assembly in New York, a spokesperson for the State Department said. The American president is due to speak in the morning session, which starts at 3 p.m. Brussels time. Puzder was due to speak at the POLITICO event at 3:30 p.m.

The cancellation came shortly after POLITICO, along with CNN and MS NOW, announced they were suing Trump and three senior advisers over the president's decision to ban their journalists from the White House complex.

AND BREATHE: Perhaps you like listening to the Brussels Playbook Podcast on your phone while out and about in the city's congested streets. Well we've got some good news. Brussels' air quality improved dramatically during Sunday's car-free day, according to Brussels Environment. Nitrogen monoxide and dioxide levels plunged 88% and 84%, respectively, at Arts-Loi in the EU Quarter (the rain also helped).

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: While other world leaders mingle at UNGA in New York, Friedrich Merz is at home facing another test of his standing with his parliamentary group.

Paris: Emmanuel Macron wants to put his stamp on the pope's visit to France on Friday, but Leo XIV refuses to turn it into a political event.

London: Andy Burnham will meet Donald Trump for the first time today — his biggest diplomatic test since becoming prime minister.

Washington: Trump unveiled a massive new helipad at the White House but the TV pool declined to cover it live following his ban on several media outlets.

Ottawa: Mark Carney's bid to "build, baby, build" is drawing fire from labor, environmentalists and Conservatives.

Canberra: Treasurer Jim Chalmers will argue today that the Albanese government is making the right moves for "dangerous" times — but its long-term solutions come with short-term pain.

AGENDA

— General Affairs Council begins, with doorsteps starting at 9 a.m. Press conference around 5:30 p.m. Watch live .

— U.N. General Assembly in New York. Commission President Ursula von der Leyen and European Council President António Costa participate in the opening at 3 p.m. (all times Brussels).

— Von der Leyen delivers remarks at a high-level dialogue on protecting children's rights in the age of AI at 9 p.m.

— Costa speaks at the high-level international meeting on the two-state solution and the Comprehensive Peace Plan for Gaza at 10:45 p.m.

— European Parliament President Roberta Metsola addresses the Clinton Global Initiative Annual Meeting at 9:30 p.m. Follow live .

— EU foreign policy chief Kaja Kallas co-hosts a high-level side event on global food security and the Black Sea with Ukraine, France and Romania in New York.

— Commission Executive Vice President Henna Virkkunen participates in a G7 meeting on AI safety and holds a videoconference with White House Office of Science and Technology Policy Director Michael Kratsios.

— Commission Executive Vice President Teresa Ribera meets businessman and former New York City Mayor Michael Bloomberg.

— Mediterranean Commissioner Dubravka Šuica co-hosts an EU-UNESCO event on information integrity and freedom of expression in the Mediterranean on the sidelines of UNGA.

— Equality Commissioner Hadja Lahbib meets UNICEF Executive Director Catherine Russell.

— Climate Commissioner Wopke Hoekstra meets Canadian Industry Minister Mélanie Joly.

— NATO Secretary-General Mark Rutte is also in the U.S., meeting Iowa Governor Kim Reynolds, visiting the Iowa National Guard Joint Forces Headquarters and speaking at an event hosted by the Chicago Council on Global Affairs. Watch here .

— Political and Security Committee meets in Brussels.

— Agriculture Commissioner Christophe Hansen meets France's European Affairs Minister Benjamin Haddad in Brussels.

****Don't miss key insights directly from the European Health Forum Gastein. Enjoy a one-week trial of our Pro Morning Healthcare Newsletter and get access to the latest developments in European health policy. ****

BIRTHDAYS

Former MEPs Estrella Durá Ferrandis, Michael Heaver and Csanád Szegedi; French politician Ségolène Royal; public policy adviser Sophie Jacobs; International Committee of the Red Cross' Chadi Sidhom; Honeywell Aerospace's Agnès Leroux; Moa Technology's Alexandra Ranson; the European Space Agency's Barend Leyts; Blandine Ronsse from FleishmanHillard.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Grier, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Milena Wälde and Daria Zakharova, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

****A message from Google: Europe's future is shaped in Brussels, and more often than not, it all starts with a cup of coffee. As AI becomes a bigger part of these conversations, how is AI made and used in Europe today? How can those policies best align with practical, everyday AI experiences? Join us at Connected Cup , an AI pop-up by Google, for hands-on demos, engaging workshops, and inspiring conversations with Europe's foremost innovators on artificial intelligence. The goal is to ground complex discussions in reality with tangible product experiences: a shared coffee space where anyone can come and see how AI works in Europe, ask questions, and connect with the people building it. Open to everyone at Rue d'Arlon, 80, from 21 September to 16 October, weekdays 08:00 to 16:00, with product demos and events. Explore the programme , or just drop by. Come for the technology; stay for the coffee!****

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